Maa and Mrs Gupta chatted for a while over snacks before dinner was served. I had insisted that I be allowed to help serve the dinner. That is when I planned my mischief. Knowing that bowls of daal would be served separately, I added red chilli powder to Mrs Gupta's bowl, enough to set her tongue on fire. To make my plan succeed, I didn't keep any water bottle on the table. The first spoonful of daal did its magic, and Mrs Gupta started to squeal. As she rapidly fanned her tongue with her hands, I ran to the kitchen and came back with a glass full of Papaji's white rum. She gulped half of it in a hurry before she realized it wasn't water. Her expression changed; her face blanched and, the next moment, she had thrown up all over the floor! Poor Mrs Gupta would remember that dinner her whole life. I was excused —everyone thought I had mistaken rum for water. After all, the bottle it was kept in was a plain glass bottle. It was then that I discovered how good I was at being mischievous.

We had scrambled out of our financial crisis by the time we moved to Tezpur, Assam, towards the end of 1983. Papaji was posted as an attaché to the General Reserve Engineer Force (GREF). We were again admitted in Kendriya Vidyalaya, where Maa had also managed to get a job as a teacher. Slowly, the lessons I had learnt during a hard times in Jabalpur faded away as I began to enjoy my new school. As I entered the sixth standard, I came up with a whole list of pranks to play on my friends, classmates and teachers. This, in turn, affected my studies, though I always managed to score average marks on the subjects I was good at. Knowing that my mother was in the same school, and that she would get me out of trouble, I took the subjects I didn't like for granted. I laid my wager on this assumed privilege. One such subject I hated was social science, so much so that I didn't do any homework for the subject for an entire month—May 1984. I didn't care until the subject teacher found out.

'Everyone, take out your homework notebooks and keep them on your table. I'm coming to check them,' Ms Meenakshi, our social science teacher, announced. She was a beautiful middled-aged lady, slim and fair, and was usually dressed in a saree. What I distinctively remember about her is her curly hair, which hung loosely around her shoulders. It was a bright